

facebook

Facebook sues bot sellers

FB has sued a New Zealand company that sold fake likes, shares, and followers on Instagram. <https://dgit.in/may19-41>

**NASA, FEMA simulate asteroid**

NASA, FEMA, and other agencies are again gearing up for a hypothetical asteroid impact. <https://dgit.in/may19-42>

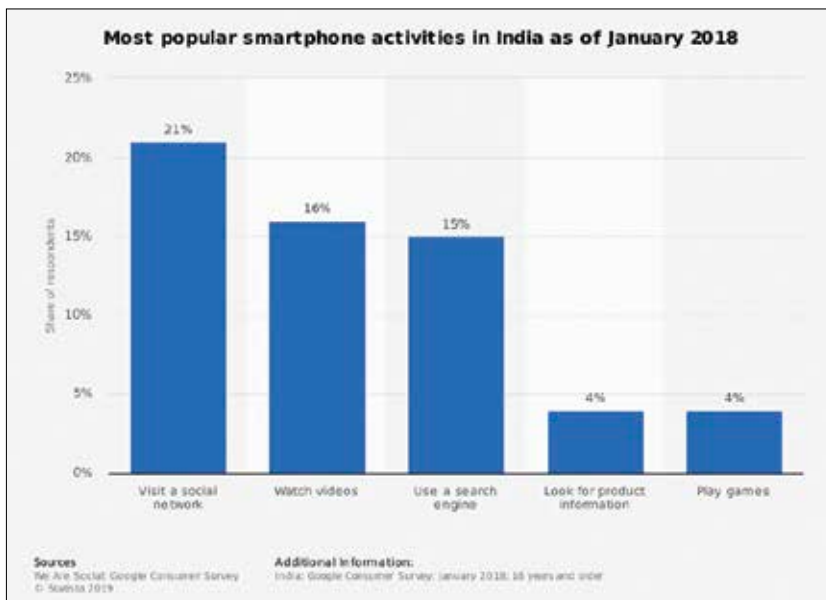
Apps like Helo and Shareit are leading the social engagement sphere, with Tiktok, Like, Kwai, Vmate and others boosting the entertainment and engagement among the top apps. Live streaming apps such as BIGO and LiveMe and Vigo Video also have a strong user base in India, often leading to high revenue through in-app purchases. The success of mobile games from Chinese-owned companies such as PUBG Mobile, Clash of Kings and Mobile Legends has also been pretty spectacular. However, an often overlooked category is utility apps, where Chinese entries like Xender, CamScanner, BeautyPlus have amassed huge user bases.

A similarity is difficult to miss here. The target group for almost all of these apps are new internet users of India, especially from smaller towns and cities. If you've used these apps and experienced their features, you'll often see content directly catering to this user group. A name that keeps recurring in this segment is Bytedance. The compa-



ny behind the hugely popular Tiktok, Bytedance also owns Vigo Video. Helo Holdings Limited, the company behind Sharechat competitor Helo, is owned by Toutiao, which in turn is a core product of the Beijing-based ByteDance. All of these companies are part of the top 100 free apps in India, with some ranking in the top 10. There are other major players too. LIKE and Bigo are both from Bigo Technologies.

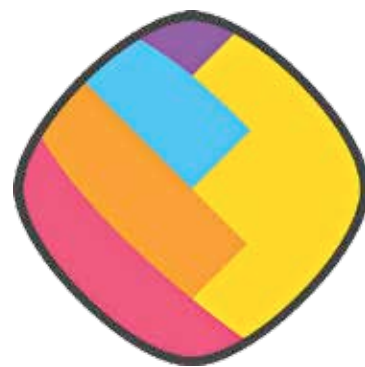
The fact that these companies are from beyond the border is a feature,



not a cause, behind their popularity. There are other factors common across all of these apps that have pushed their numbers to where they are right now. For instance, almost all of these apps have strong support for vernacular languages. Content creation platforms like TikTok, LIKE and live streaming platforms like Bigo even highlight vernacular content creators on their platforms. There's also the ability to have a quick interaction that does not involve a long attention span. For instance, short video creation and sharing apps such as Tiktok and LIKE have seen massive growth in popularity as well as influence over their audiences. Another often ignored factor is the user interface.

These apps, especially those reliant on content consumption, put users in some form of a never-ending cycle of viewing and content discovery. This could be through an endless scrollable feed, driving traffic between profiles through collaborations. These apps also employ technology like machine learning to determine your usage patterns and keep exposing content, you're bound to engage with, at you endlessly. Another interesting factor about the user experience is that there's hardly any difference between two competing apps in terms of app design and features. Everything, down

to where similar buttons are placed to how you can interact with the content on the app, is similar between direct competitors, reducing the learning curve that a user has to go through when choosing between apps. Also, while internet connectivity in India might have spread far and wide, the quality of that connectivity remains questionable. Popular apps have even accounted for this by releasing Lite versions of their apps that get around bandwidth and speed issues.

**WHERE IS IT HEADED?**

Companies at the helm of the popular narrative in apps right now aren't willing to let it go that easily. Tiktok was recently at the centre of controversy after inappropriate content on the platform led to a court-issued ban. While